Harsha Vemulapalli

Design & Research Executive | Enterprise SaaS & Platforms

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SUMMARY

Design and research executive with 25+ years of experience and 16 years leading multi-disciplinary organizations spanning product design, user research, design systems, content strategy, and localization. Grew Siemens' global experience organization from 5 to 70 people across seven countries as a manager of managers, and led design through enterprise transformations at Siemens, VMware, and Bosch. AI-forward leader who sets org-wide AI strategy, from research agents and AI-driven localization to AI-assisted prototyping that ships to production, and pairs adoption with evaluation standards that protect research rigor. Holds the quality bar on accessibility and craft across enterprise SaaS, marketplace, and global multi-language platforms.

SELECTED IMPACT

- Led experience design for Siemens Xcelerator Marketplace, a **€9.4B digital sales channel that grew 19%** in FY2025.
- Built and scaled design organizations of **70 (Siemens), 75 (VMware), ~120 (Bosch), and 140 (GM)**; grew **10+ designers into manager and director roles**.
- Drove AI into the work itself: **–34% time-to-insight** with a research agent; **+23% conversion and +28% engagement** from an AI product finder.
- Own a **$2M annual operating budget** (excluding salaries), report to the SVP of eCommerce, and partner with Product and Engineering leadership on roadmap and tradeoffs.

SKILLS

Organization Leadership: Manager of managers · Org design & scaling · Career paths & development programs · Remote, globally distributed teams · Psychological safety · Executive influence with Product & Engineering

AI Strategy & Adoption: Org-wide AI strategy · AI-assisted research synthesis · LLM evaluation & hallucination guardrails · Agentic workflows · Conversational UX · AI-assisted SDLC (Figma Make, Claude Code, React prototyping)

Research & Content: Research methodologies & ResearchOps · Insight-led product strategy · A/B testing & experimentation · Content strategy · Globalization & localization · AI-assisted translation

Quality & Systems: Design system governance & adoption · Accessibility (WCAG 2.1) · Design critique & review · Workflow automation for design & content compliance · Experience metrics & scorecards

EXPERIENCE

Global Director, Experience Design & Research 2025 – Present

Siemens Digital Industries Software · Detroit, MI

Lead a 70-person organization across seven countries spanning UX design, research, content, localization, and design operations for Siemens Xcelerator Marketplace and global platforms.

- Grew the organization from 5 to 70 (about 58 employees plus embedded contractors) through layers of senior managers; built a co-created skills framework and career growth tool that defines paths and expectations at every level.
- Set the org's AI agenda: led a Microsoft Copilot research agent over a unified research repository (**–34% time-to-insight, +20% data utilization**) and a persona agent grounded in 80 interviews and 800+ surveys, now in daily use by research and approved for the extended design team, with accuracy and hallucination evaluation gating wider rollout.
- Led the One Siemens design system and governance model, consolidating **150+ sites, 100K+ pages, and 3,000+ content creators** onto shared components and standards.
- Own localization, translation, and currency across **38 regions and 32 languages**, where regions can carry multiple languages and currencies; use AI tools to tailor content to each market.
- Hold the quality bar at scale: no UI moves to development without an accessibility review, and built **workflow automation** that validates design-system compliance in design and brand, accessibility (WCAG 2.1), and content-strategy compliance in content authoring.

- Led the Xcelerator Marketplace experience from go-live, partnering as a peer with VP and SVP business leaders on its growth; built third-party page templates that made the marketplace a home for partner products and services.

Director of User Experience, DISW Apr 2023 – 2025
Siemens Digital Industries Software · Detroit, MI

- Owned UX, research, and content for Digital Industries Software's web properties and purchase and finance funnels for technical and non-technical customers.
- Player/coach on an AI-powered product finder: cut scope to the customer's next step, drew the initial layout, validated with 5-second and data-driven tests, prototyped in Figma Make, and shipped in React on Contentful; **+23% conversion and +28% engagement**, measured in Amplitude.
- Ran 2–3 A/B tests a week across the site with design, marketing, communications, and sales teams.

Senior Manager, UX Smart Vehicle Sep 2022 – Jan 2023
Amazon · 13-person team

- Directed design and research for a multi-stakeholder vehicle platform with embedded commerce, media, and advertising; introduced leaner processes that cut timelines 12%.

Senior Director, User Experience Design & Research Apr 2021 – Sep 2022
VMware · 75-person team

- Led design, research, experience strategy, and service design through VMware's subscription-to-SaaS transformation.
- Redesigned mission-critical CPQ quoting workflows for **35,000+ users, cutting time-on-task 30%** and accelerating SaaS deal velocity.
- Shipped an experience scorecard used by thousands of employees; re-platformed hybrid-work systems while holding **75%+ CSAT and reducing support load 20%**.
- Developed senior ICs into leaders across a distributed team while contributing directly to critical design work.

Director, Digital Brand, UX and Research Oct 2019 – Apr 2021
CARFAX · 30-person team

- Led end-to-end product redesign for **+7% conversion and −26% dev churn**; established a research cadence that informed product and brand strategy.

Head of Design, North America Oct 2016 – Oct 2019
Robert Bosch, LLC · grew from 0 to ~120

- Built Bosch's internal design consultancy from employee zero to ~120 people (5 direct, 90 indirect), and scaled a design thinking framework that let non-designers build human-centered solutions.
- Drove service design initiatives that **saved $6M**; led research and design for an AI/ML infotainment system that lowered hardware costs and glance times.

User Experience Manager Sep 2014 – Oct 2016
General Motors · team scaled to 140

- Built a pattern-driven global strategy that launched **7 mobile apps in 23 languages** within one year across seven brands.
- Created an in-app services revenue stream exceeding **$1M in its first year**.

Earlier: Design Manager, Air Mobility Command (U.S. Air Force) · UX & Analytics Manager, CDC (70M+ page views a year) · Interaction Designer, Blackbaud · Product Manager, Morris Digitalworks

EDUCATION, CERTIFICATIONS & SPEAKING

B.S., Information Technology, American InterContinental University

Certifications: Decision by Design (Farnam Street) · Google AI Essentials · Behavioral Design (Irrational Labs) · UX Research (University of Denver) · Certified Scrum Product Owner & ScrumMaster

Speaking & research: "Leading Teams through AI" panel, Research Guild (2025) · Forrester, Leveraging AI for B2B e-commerce (2025) · IDC MarketScape, Digital B2B Ecosystems (2025) · Automotive Cockpit HMI (2018) · AV18 (2018)